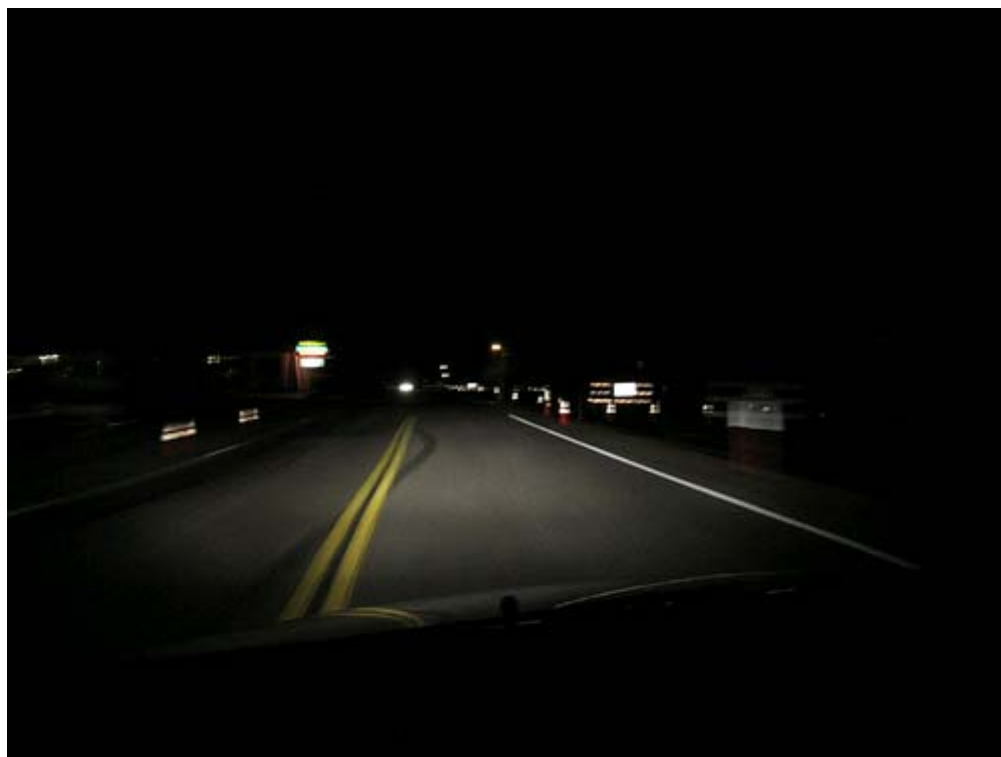


*June 6th & 7th, 2009*

*2 day backpack to Horton Lake above Bishop with an attempt to climb Mt Tom & Basin Mtn.*

The weekend started out not looking very promising. The weather forecasts had been going downhill all week and there was now a winter storm advisory that allegedly included a few inches of fresh snow and some significant lightning activity around Bishop. That's a bad thing if you're trying to get up to 13,600 ft on the tallest bare rock point in the local area.

Due to various issues ranging from foot surgery to the belief we'd be camping in rather cold weather the group I had planned to lead up to the peaks ended up being just Kim and I. Never one to give up easily I planned to go even if it came down to just me.



So, as usual 8 pm saw me driving north from Orange County this time heading to the east side of the Sierra above the town of Bishop. It was a late night made worse by the fact once we rolled into Bishop sometime after 1 am we still had a long dirt road to drive. And to say the dirt road is in bad shape would be a bit of an understatement. It's long and in horrible condition.



Finally the road was bad enough I just found a spot and pulled over and we would hike the rest of the way along the road in the morning. It was now in the area of 2:30 am and we were both exhausted. I set out an emergency blanket and we slept out on the ground.

It was actually a rather good (if short) night's sleep. At some point we were both woken up by a coyote howling right on the other side of the road but other than that I slept well.

After unsuccessfully trying to rouse Kim at dawn for the hike in I let her sleep in a bit.



I finally managed to rouse her and started getting our packs ready. The morning saw blue skies towards where we were headed (the peak above is Mt Tom.)



And a visible storm front to the south.



The hike in to Horton Lake is 4 miles and 2300 ft from the trailhead and most of it is pretty gradual.



Part way up we came to the first of several mine remnants, a cabin and structure labeled Sonny Boy Mine. We could smell something cooking and when we got closer found a smoldering fire with a

complete set of camping and fishing gear sitting nearby but no sign of the owner. We poked around inside the cabin (which would be the perfect setting for a horror film) and continued on.





Next we came to a nice meadow where we took a brief break before re-shouldering our packs and pushing on to Horton.



Finally we reached Horton Lakes itself. Here the old mining cabins were locked so we didn't spend a lot of time there. Instead we continued down towards the lake and set up camp.



I was a bit put out by the lack of lightning and other bad weather. I had brought my heavy gear due to the forecast and now felt a bit silly putting up the 4 season tent amid sprinkles and light flurries.



Unfortunately Kim didn't feel up to a long day hike which meant the first of the peaks were no longer an option. By then snow had started to fall on some of the surrounding peaks and I would have a 6+ hour round trip hike across rock and snow fields with no one to go for help if anything happened. Reluctantly I gave up on Basin Mountain and set my hopes on doing Mt Tom Sunday morning.





It never got down much past freezing so we spent a relatively warm and uneventful night camped by the lake. The next morning we emerged to blue skies ready to climb.



The trail climbs the slope above but it's almost impossible to make out from below. It was once a drivable road and you can still see the twin ruts in places. Elsewhere erosion and rock fall have reduced it to barely enough to talk on.



The lake from above.

About two hours later we came to the top of the ridge.



Here trouble began. We had a clear view of the peak 2,000 ft above but now dark clouds were gathering around it.



I had been warned of significant lighting activity the previous week and I really didn't want to get caught in an electrical storm while climbing the largest pile of rocks in the area. Dark clouds were also coming at us from the opposite direction.

I was reluctant to turn us around so close to the peak but Kim wasn't moving very fast while meant if we had to turn around in a hurry due to down strikes it would be a slow and nerve-racking retreat. That combined with the fact we would be exposed far above tree line with another ridge to cover before we could drop below it made me very uncomfortable.

(And I'm taller than Kim so I'd be hit first.)





I delayed us for a short while in the hopes the clouds would dissipate. We crossed a snow field to the nearby Hanging Valley Mine site but as soon as we made it over there I decided things were looking even worse and turned us around.

We went back down the way we came, both feeling discouraged we'd missed our chance at hitting the peak.



Sadly after another hour or so the big poofy clouds turned into a standard rain / snow layer, something I'd climb into without worry. Unfortunately it was too late by then to climb back up the ridge.



We relaxed briefly in camp then packed up and headed for the car.



Several hours later we were back at Kim's car and started the long drive home. I think I managed a whole 30 minutes in bed before I had to get up at 4 am and drive to the airport!

Next weekend is now up in the air. I was originally joining a group to climb two higher peaks in the Bishop area but that trip has since been canceled. I'm hoping to join a rather fun looking expedition that will include the SPS emblem peak Abbott but I'm waiting to hear back. If not it's probably going to be a private trip back to the South Sierra.